While Niranjan Prasad and John Dalvi awaited fresh orders from the top, the Chinese stepped up their activities. From their 7-ton roadhead at Marmang, a few miles from Thagla, they used Tibetan ponies to bring mortars and guns across the ridge and fortified their positions with the thoroughness and skill that had earlier been demonstrated by them during the Korean conflict. Two dozen Indian observation posts were sending in detailed reports to Brigade HQ that was located away from the Nam Ka Chu, in depth behind the Assam Rifles post at Dhola and Bridge 3. They reported all the Chinese activity including the taking of bearings of Indian positions for the silent registration of targets. Dalvi himself observed a jeep reaching the top of the Thagla with a senior Chinese officer on board. On 19 October, the Rajput observation post at Temporary Bridge counted 1,978 Chinese soldiers at Tseng Jong. All this information, along with grid references, was being relayed to HQ 4 Division which had somewhat unceremoniously been shifted to Zimithang from Tezpur so it could be closer to the front.

As all this was going on, 7 Brigade HQ had waited in vain for the one order that would allow them to pull the main body of troops back from their suicidal deployment. Finally, after sundown on 19 October, with the clock ticking away, Prasad called Dalvi and asked him to move the remaining body of 1/9 Gorkhas to Tsangle at first light the next day. Dalvi, shocked, asked the GOC if he had been reading all the reports that had been filed through the day about the Chinese build up.

Dalvi once again pleaded for permission to withdraw from the river. Finally, Prasad gave him the news that Kaul had fallen ill and had had to be evacuated to Delhi on 18 October. The GOC categorically stated that there was no one in the chain of command who could revoke the personal order given by the corps commander.

Asking Dalvi not to do anything rash, Prasad conveyed the brigade commander’s appreciation to HQ IV Corps. The three main points were: (a) On 20 October the Chinese would definitely wipe out the Indians at Tsangle (b) Within the next two days, the Chinese would drive a wedge between and through 2 Rajput positions and capture Tsangdhar. When this happened the whole brigade would be overrun, and (c) due to the present dispersal and lack of troops, the Chinese would have a walkover, as they would have to contend with only two or three infantry companies, who, without any